



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Dayspring Christian Academy
School Website: <https://www.dayspringchristian.com/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS STARTUP

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because ACCS require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: **CLASSICAL**

Executive Summary

Dayspring Christian Academy (Lancaster County, PA) presents a classical Christian orientation with strong theological grounding and a formation-first approach. Public-facing materials emphasize biblical authority, virtue, and character formation, alongside organized intellectual aims rooted in a Principle Approach. The school climate strongly foregrounds God's Word, prayer, song, and liturgical-like rhythms in daily life, while also signaling a college-preparatory track in the upper grades. While the religious/metaphysical foundations and purpose/goals are clearly CLASSICAL, the explicit pedagogy and curriculum details align more with a historic classical framework in some areas and with a more faith-centric formation model in others. Overall, the school is BEST described as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, with clear pathways toward CLASSICAL in certain domains and notable gaps in others (notably explicit Great Books emphasis and some conventional catechetical/Scholé signals). This conclusion is supported by the school's own materials and the classical rubric.

- **Religious and Metaphysical Foundations:** CLASSICAL Evidence includes the explicit Lordship of Christ, biblical worldview, and daily integration of God's Word into instruction (e.g., "Acknowledge the Lordship of Jesus Christ in every area of life" and "Every class at Dayspring Christian Academy begins with God's Word").
- **Purpose and Goal:** CLASSICAL Evidence shows formation of virtue and Christian character, not merely information, with emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness in a biblical frame and a classical mission.
- **Curriculum:** SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Evidence points to a classical flavor (Principle Approach, history-as-breadth, field studies, memory work), but explicit Great Books, classic trivium/quadrivium emphasis, or explicit Great Conversation framing is not consistently articulated in the public materials. The daily/weekly rhythms foreground Bible, history, literature, and memory work, rather than a stated Great Books program.
- **Pedagogy:** SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Evidence indicates lower-school contemplative/repetitive memory and singing, with upper-school potential for discussion, but explicit Socratic seminars or rhetoric-focused pedagogy are not clearly documented in the site copy. The presence of memory work, chanting, and liturgical-like cadence aligns with scholé signals, but lack of explicit, widespread Socratic/seminar language places this in the "somewhat" zone.
- **Faculty:** SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Evidence demonstrates teachers as virtuous exemplars in a "Principle Approach" framework, but explicit language about "living curriculum," portrait of the teacher, or a robust faculty-learning-community language is not consistently spelled out in public pages. Still, there is a sense of model-teacher/mentorship through the biblical-principle approach.
- **Parents & Community:** CLASSICAL Evidence shows intentional partnership with families and churches, parent formation opportunities, and open-campus hospitality, with explicit statements that

parents are co-teachers and involved in classical formation. This aligns with the classical model's emphasis on family formation and parental partnership.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- **Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL Evidence:** Lordship of Christ, biblical worldview, daily Word-led instruction, liturgical-like cadence in schooling (prayer, song). Positive keywords present: truth (biblical truth), theology, liturgy/worship (liturgical practices in school rhythm), reverence/wonder. Negative keywords: none clearly present. Why: The school foregrounds transcendent truths and biblical foundations in every class, which aligns strongly with classical religious metaphysical foundations.
- **Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL Evidence:** Formation of virtue and Christian character; reference to truth/beauty/goodness; partnership with families to form citizens of excellence in Christian character and scholarship. Positive keywords: formation, virtue, wisdom, classical mission, telos. Negative keywords: workforce preparation emphasis is present only as a secondary dimension (college prep). Why: The core aim is formation and virtue within a classical frame, even as college-prep exists in practice.
- **Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Evidence:** Principle Approach; field studies; integration of history/history-informed instruction; Bible-centered study; emphasis on memory and literature across subjects. Positive keywords: liberal arts (implied by “Principle Approach” and classical framing), history, literature, field studies, memory. Negative keywords: lack of explicit Great Books/Great Conversation and explicit trivium/quadrivium wording in public materials. Why: The curriculum leans classical in spirit and method but is not consistently explicit about core standards (Great Books, explicit grammar/logic/rhetoric triad) as the public-facing materials present them.
- **Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Evidence:** Lower-level emphasis on singing, memory and review; upper-level emphasis on discussion are suggested but not clearly documented as a universal practice; Schedule includes Bible, memory verses, and liturgical-style review. Positive keywords: memory work, chanting, recitation, restfulness, contemplation. Negative: limited explicit mention of wide Socratic seminars or structured rhetorical training beyond general classical framing. Why: Pedagogy includes scholé-like elements and memory-driven practice, with some sign of higher-level discussion, but not a consistently documented, fully classical pedagogy across all grades.
- **Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Evidence:** Emphasis on teachers as virtuous exemplars and on the Principle Approach, which positions the teacher as a central figure in formation. Positive keywords: model teachers, living curriculum, mentors, portrait of a teacher. Negative: The public materials do not consistently describe a formal “faculty as living curriculum” or a robust “faculty portrait” program. Why: The school leans on faculty as character-forming agents and as central to the curriculum, but explicit classical faculty development language is not consistently present.
- **Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL Evidence:** Partnership with parents; parents as co-teachers; parent formation and open visits; tours; community and liturgical-year events. Positive keywords: partnership with parents, co-teachers, parent formation, open campus, family liturgy alignment. Negative: None identified in public-facing materials. Why: The school explicitly centers parents in the classical formation project, aligning with “parents as co-teachers” and active parental involvement.

Aggregate assessment: The six categories split about evenly between CLASSICAL and SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. While religious/metaphysical foundations, purpose/goal, and parent/community show robust CLASSICAL alignment, curriculum, pedagogy, and faculty reveal more mixed signals (strong formation language but less explicit traditional classical pedagogy or Great Books framing). Overall classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

What Would Move the Needle

- Make Great Books/Great Conversation explicit across grade bands, with a public-facing statement of intent and a concrete plan (e.g., listing canonical works, schedules for canonical reading, and integrated Socratic seminars) to elevate Curriculum and Pedagogy to CLASSICAL.
- Elevate explicit “Socratic” or seminar-based teaching across grades (not just a mention in high school) to strengthen Pedagogy alignment with classical norms.
- Expand the Faculty section with a clearly articulated “living curriculum” concept, a formal portrait of what a classical teacher should be, and professional development rooted in classical pedagogy.
- Expand liturgical/community practices into explicit, regular communal rites (e.g., formal prayer services, liturgical calendar integration) that are clearly described on the site as part of the learning process to strengthen Religious and Metaphysical Foundations and Pedagogy.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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